Captain's Guide

companion page for the Dietary Needs Grid

This is the least glamorous sheet in the kit and the one that makes the whole thing work. Fill it in with the family before a single lasagna exists, and you've done the hard, invisible part of a great meal train.

How to fill it without it feeling like a form

— Do it on the phone or over coffee. "So — what does everyone in the house actually eat?" is a friendlier opener than "dietary questionnaire."

— One row per person, including the kids. A nine-year-old who "hates squash with a passion" is not a logistics problem; they're a celery-and- peanut-butter customer with opinions.

— Ask the allergy question plainly: "Is there anything in this house that could genuinely hurt someone?" Then write it word for word.

Copy it everywhere

— Attach a copy to the sign-up sheet, tuck one in the cooler, and text a photo of it to each volunteer with their date.

— Circle anything severe and tape an allergen flag to the sheet next to it, so nobody has to rely on memory in the baking aisle.

— Update it if anything changes — new doctor's orders, a new fish allergy, a kid who has decided pasta is over.

Gentle gotchas

— Avoid-words are not the same as bans. "Dislikes mushrooms" means don't feature mushrooms; "severe allergy: shellfish" means wash the pot twice.

— Ask once, then don't re-interrogate. People in hard seasons are tired of explaining themselves; that's what this sheet is for.

Getting the food right is the whole point, and this grid is how it happens. You're not being fussy — you're being the person who made sure every single meal arrived safe to eat. That's real care.